

**St. John's N.S.
Ballinalee Road,
Edgeworthstown,
Co. Longford
N39 F211
043 6671620
Email: info@stjohnsnsedgeworthstown.ie**

Code of Behaviour

Introduction:

Our School aims to provide a happy, secure, friendly, learning environment, where children, parents, teachers, ancillary staff and Board of Management work in partnership. Each individual pupil is valued, encouraged and respected for their uniqueness and facilitated to reach their full potential in a positive atmosphere. The purpose of this policy is to promote positive behaviour and to allow the school to function in an orderly and harmonious way whilst promoting a high level of respect and cooperation between staff, parents and pupils.

Rationale:

We wish to ensure our policy and practice at St. John's N.S. is in compliance with all legal requirements and good practice as set out in 'Developing a Code of Behaviour: Guidelines for Schools, NEWB, 2008.

Aims of the policy:

- To allow the school to function in an orderly way where children can make progress in all aspects of their development.
- To create an atmosphere of respect, tolerance and consideration for others.
- To promote positive behaviour and self-discipline, recognising the differences between children and the need to accommodate these differences.
- To ensure the safety and well-being of all members of the school community.
- To assist parents and pupils in understanding the systems and procedures that form part of the code of behaviour and to seek their cooperation in the application of these procedures.
- To ensure that the system of rules and sanctions are implemented in a fair and consistent manner throughout the school.

1. Guidelines for behaviour in the school

- The standards of behaviour the school wishes to promote are as follows:
 - Each pupil is expected to be well behaved and to show consideration for other children and adults.
 - Each pupil is expected to show respect for the property of the school, other children's property and their own belongings.
 - Each pupil is expected to attend school on a regular basis and to be punctual.
 - Each pupil is expected to do his/her best at all times.

- We recognise that factors influencing children's behaviour may sometimes need to be considered and accommodated.

2. Whole school approach in promoting positive behaviour

The elements of a whole school approach to behaviour include:

- An ethos, policies and practices that are in harmony
- A teamwork approach to behaviour
- A whole-school approach to curriculum and classroom management
- An inclusive and involved school community
- A systematic process for planning and reviewing behaviour policy

Board of Management

- Has a duty of care for the pupils attending the school
- Must fulfil its obligations for all members of the school community under the Safety, Health and Welfare at Work Act (2005)
- Must ensure the school is a safe environment for pupils, teachers and all other members of the school community
- Must ensure that all members of the school community are involved in the drawing up and implementation of the Code
- Was actively involved in reviewing this Code of Behaviour.
- Supports the Code of Behaviour in the school by endorsing every aspect of it and complying with the various procedures involved in suspension or expulsion.
- Supports the staff in implementing the Code of Behaviour by facilitating funding for any training that may be deemed necessary.

Parents/Guardians

- Have the right to have a safe and welcoming environment for their child and to be treated with respect
- Co-operation between staff and parents is encouraged by meeting with parents of new Junior Infants at an information evening at the beginning of the school year. Formal parent/teacher meetings are also held annually. Parents are informed that they may arrange a meeting by appointment with the class teacher if they have any concerns regarding their child.
- Were actively involved in reviewing this Code of Behaviour.
- The Code of Behaviour is published on the school website. Parents are required to confirm in writing that the Code of Behaviour is acceptable to them and that they shall make all reasonable efforts to ensure compliance with such code by the child.
- Parents with an issue regarding another child's behaviour during school time should bring the matter to the teacher's attention. It is not recommended that they deal with the matter themselves.
- Parents support the school in the promotion of positive behaviour and the maintenance of high standards of behaviour in the following ways:
 - Parents are aware of and co-operate with the school's system of rules and sanctions.
 - Parents ensure their children attend regularly and punctually.

- Parents attend meetings at the school if requested.
- Parents help their children with homework and ensure that it is completed.
- Parents ensure their children have the necessary books and materials for school.
- Parents ensure their children wear the correct uniform.
- Parents communicate constructively with school staff and Board of Management in matters affecting their child.
- Parents should ensure that their child has an acceptable level of hygiene as a courtesy to other pupils.
- Parents should make the school aware of any relevant changes/stress in the home environment which may affect the child's behaviour.

❖ **Staff**

- Teachers have the right to be treated with respect; teach in a safe, appropriate physical environment and to have support and cooperation from pupils, parents, colleagues and Board of Management.
- Teachers are expected to support and implement the school's Code of Behaviour; create an inclusive and positive learning environment for each pupil and promote cooperation with parents/guardians for the benefit of each pupil's education.
- The Code of Behaviour is available on the website to new and temporary staff.
- The Code of Behaviour caters for children who may present behavioural difficulties arising from their special education needs. This is done by ensuring that standards and rules are communicated by teachers in a way that students with special educational needs can understand. There will be a particular need for these pupils to be reminded of the rules and to check their understanding of the rules.
- The school's SPHE curriculum is used to support the Code of Behaviour. It aims to help the pupils develop communication skills, appropriate ways of interacting and behaving, and conflict resolution skills. It also aims to foster self-esteem and to help children accommodate differences and develop citizenship. The SPHE curriculum is delivered as stated in the SPHE policy.

❖ **Pupils**

- Pupils have the right to be treated fairly, consistently and with respect
- Pupils are expected to cooperate with all staff within the school community; to accept the authority and rules of the school and to respect all members of the school community, including peers, staff and school property.
- Pupils were involved in reviewing the Code of Behaviour by working with the class teachers to draw up classroom and playground rules.
- Pupils are given the opportunity to monitor and review the code of behaviour during SPHE classes when discussions are held on behaviour and pupils are reminded of the rules.

Behaviour in class

Courtesy and respect are essential. Disrespectful behaviour towards other pupils or towards a teacher (e.g. defiance, cheek, insolence) are unacceptable. Pupils must respect the right of other pupils to learn. Any behaviour which interferes with the right (e.g. constant disruption of the class, persistent distracting of others) is considered unacceptable behaviour. In order that pupils

benefit from their work in class full cooperation is required at all times. Pupils must cooperate with instructions given by the teacher.

The Essential Classroom Rules

1. Be ready for class
2. Good manners are expected at all times
3. Always do your best and allow others to do the same
4. Raise hand, wait for attention and listen to the person who is speaking
5. Take good care of personal and classroom property
6. Ensure you are safe in class and make it safe for others

Behaviour in the Playground

Pupils should treat others as they would like to be treated themselves. Any behaviour which endangers or offends others is not permitted. Rough behaviour e.g. fighting, kicking, spitting, pushing is forbidden. Games or activities considered to be dangerous shall be prohibited.

Any behaviour which interferes with other pupils' play is not permitted. Pupils may not leave the playground for any reason during breaks without permission of the supervising teacher. This includes re-entering the school building.

The Essential Playground Rules

1. Stay within the boundaries in yard
2. Play safely and fairly. Treat others fairly, the way you would like yourself to be treated
3. Keep yard and school environment litter free and tidy
4. Stay clear of fire alarm and respect all school property
5. Leave and return to the classroom in an orderly fashion.

3. Positive strategies for managing behaviour

The following are the positive strategies used throughout the school to promote good behaviour and to prevent misbehaviour:

● **Classroom:**

- Pupils have had an input in devising the classroom rules. (see Appendix 1.)
- Teachers ensure that pupils understand, and are frequently reminded of, how they are expected to behave.
- A clear system of sanctions for misbehaviour is adhered to.
- Classroom management techniques ensure that a variety of activities and methodologies to sustain pupil interest and motivation are in place.
- Timetabling is arranged in keeping with Department guidelines.

● **Playground:**

- Pupils have had an input in devising the playground rules. (see Appendix 1.)
- Pupils are not allowed to go out to the yard without permission.

- The playground is always supervised at break times. This supervision is carried out by the class teacher. If a SNA has been appointed to a particular child he/she could assist the supervisor in the playground.
- When pupils are going to and returning from the playground they are supervised by the teacher on duty.
- The teacher on duty will also administer first aid to children who suffer injury during playtime.
- On wet days, or other days when the use of the playground is deemed unsuitable, pupils remain indoors in their own classroom, under the supervision of their class teacher. They are allowed to play suitable games i.e. board games, jigsaws etc.
- Incidents of serious/gross misbehaviour are recorded in an incident book. The incident is reported to the classroom teacher and parents will be notified.

Other areas in the school:

Children are regularly reminded that they must be quiet when going to and from the toilets and when using the hand basins in the back corridor of the school. This is an area common to both classrooms and any noise can cause disturbance to both classrooms. Children are not allowed access to the office, kitchen or bathroom unless they have been given permission by their teacher.

Restorative Practice

Restorative Practice in our school provides a focus on developing positive relationships between all members of the school community. It gives opportunities for pupils to take responsibility for their behaviour and learning. Restorative Practice is a process whereby children are given the opportunity to reflect on their behaviour and how they and others have been affected by it so as to help heal broken relationships and prevent reoccurrence. Where suspension occurs, the school will use restorative practice involving all parties affected to help repair the harm done.

Restorative Questions to respond to Challenging Behaviour

1. What happened?
2. What were you thinking about at the time?
3. What have your thoughts been since?
4. Who has been affected by what you did?
5. In what way have they been affected?
6. What do you think needs to happen to make things right?

To help those harmed by other actions

1. What did you think when you realised what had happened?
2. What have your thoughts been since?
3. How has this affected others?
4. What has been the hardest thing for you?
5. What do you think needs to happen to make things right?

4. Rewards and Sanctions

Rewards and acknowledgement of good behaviour

- Individual pupil or classroom-based achievement (winning a competition etc.) is acknowledged during assembly.

- Teachers operate their own reward systems as appropriate or as/when deemed necessary. Different reward systems work better with different age groups and may need to be adapted to suit the needs of particular classes and even individuals within that class group.

❖ **Strategies for dealing with unacceptable behaviour**

- The following behaviours are seen as unacceptable: being cheeky, telling lies, teasing, bullying, using bad language, using rude gestures, abusing property, noisy and disruptive behaviour, deliberate disobedience, deliberate time wasting, kicking, fighting, spitting, injuring others, being unkind to others, throwing objects, stealing, threatening others.
- For the purpose of example, minor misbehaviour might include being cheeky or teasing. Serious misbehaviour might be fighting or abusing property. Gross misbehaviour could include injuring others or stealing. The degree of misdemeanours i.e. minor, serious or gross, will be judged by the teachers and/or Principal based on a common sense approach with regard to the gravity/frequency of such misdemeanours.
- Positive encouragement and reinforcement are regarded as primary in helping pupils to develop responsibility, a positive attitude and self-discipline. However, where a pupil wilfully disregards school rules and infringes on the rights of others, sanctions may be needed. The following are the sanctions we have put in place and are listed in order of severity depending on the nature of the misbehaviour and whether it is a repeated behaviour.
 - (a) Reasoning with the pupil
 - (b) Reprimand (including advice on how to improve)
 - (c) Temporary separation from peers, friends or others
 - (d) Loss of privileges
 - (e) Detention during break
 - (f) Prescribing additional work
 - (g) Referral to Principal Teacher / letter of apology required
 - (h) Communication with parents
 - (i) Suspension
 - (j) Expulsion
- Minor misbehaviour will be dealt with under (a) to (f), serious misbehaviour would involve (g) to (h), gross misbehaviour will be dealt with under (g) to (j).
- In the case of (a) to (f) the class teacher would apply the sanctions. If these sanctions were seen to fail to resolve the problem or the misbehaviour was of a serious/ gross manner then the principal would need to be involved and possibly the parents also. In the case of the need to implement (i) or (j) then the BOM would also be involved in dealing with the issue.
- Consistency in the application of sanctions is ensured by good communication between the members of staff and the keeping of records of serious misbehaviour.

❖ **Involving parents in management of problem behaviour**

- Parents are contacted if sanctions to deal with minor misbehaviour are seen to fail.
- Parents will be contacted immediately in the case of serious/ gross misbehaviour.
- Parents will be contacted by the principal in writing or by phone and parents may be requested to attend a meeting in the school.
- Those present at the meeting with the parents would usually be the principal and teacher/teachers involved.
- In some cases the child will be present for part of or all of the meeting.

- Parents are encouraged to contact the school if they have concerns. They are requested to make an appointment for a time mutually suitable to both parties.
- When a child engages in repeated acts of minor misbehaviour a regular reporting system may be operated between the parent and the classroom teacher.

❖ **Managing aggressive or violent misbehaviour**

- Children who are emotionally disturbed are referred for psychological assessment.
- Appropriate support is sought from services available e.g. Health Service Executive/ NEPS etc

❖ **Applying sanctions in response to behaviour that takes place outside of school**

- The standards and rules contained in this Code of Behaviour also apply in any situation where the student, although outside the school, is still the responsibility of the school. Such occasions would include school tours, games, and attendance at any events organised by the school where the teaching staff are present.
- The school does not assume any responsibility for behaviour which takes place on the bus which transports children to and from the school.

5. Suspension / Expulsion:

❖ **Suspension**

Suspension is defined as requiring the pupil to absent himself/ herself from the school for a specified, limited period of school days.

Suspension should be a proportionate response to the behaviour that is causing concern. Normally, other interventions will have been tried before suspension, and school staff will have reviewed the reasons why these have not worked. The decision to suspend a pupil requires serious grounds such that:

- The pupil's misbehaviour has had a seriously detrimental effect on the education of other pupils
- The pupil's continued presence in the school at this time constitutes a threat to safety.
- The student is responsible for serious damage to property.

A single incident of serious misconduct may be grounds for suspension.

● **Procedures in respect of suspension:**

- Ensure all other means of dealing with the behaviour have been tried.
- Previous communication will have been made with parents regarding misbehaviour.
- A fair investigation will have taken place, taking parents' and pupil's perspective into account. (page 67 *NEWB Guidelines for Developing School Codes of Behaviour*)
- If the BOM is likely to reach a decision to exclude a pupil, it will ensure the decision will be reached in an unbiased manner. *NEWB Guidelines for Developing School Codes of Behaviour P67/68*
- Parents will be informed in writing as to the nature of the complaint, how it will be investigated and that it could result in suspension. The school will keep a record of any such correspondence.
- Parents are invited to the school to discuss the intention to exclude.
- Parents and pupils will be given an opportunity to respond before a decision is made and before any sanction is imposed.
- Immediate suspension is warranted where the safety of the pupil, other pupils, staff or others is at risk.

- A student should not be suspended for more than three days, except in exceptional circumstances where the Principal considers that a period of suspension longer than three days is in order.
- If a suspension longer than three days is being proposed by the principal, the matter should be referred to the Board of Management for consideration and approval.
- Following such consideration a ceiling of ten days is, normally, placed on any one period of suspension.
- The Board will formally review any proposal to suspend a pupil, where the suspension would bring the number of days for which the pupil has been suspended in the current school year to twenty days or more. Any such suspension is subject to appeal under section 29 of the Education Act 1998.
- Where a student has been suspended for a cumulative total of six or more days, 'TUSLA: Educational Welfare Services – Child and Family Agency' is notified using the standard form. (Forms are available on the TUSLA website)

❖ **Implementing the Suspension:**

The principal will notify the parents and the pupil in writing of the decision to suspend. The letter will confirm:

- The period of suspension and the dates on which the suspension will begin and end
- The reasons for the suspension.
- Any study programme to be followed.
- The arrangements for returning to school, including parents being asked to reaffirm their commitment to the code of behaviour.
- The provision for an appeal to the Board of Management.
- The right to appeal to the Secretary General of the Dept. of Education and Science (Education Act 1998, section 29)
- The letter will be clear and easy to understand with particular care being taken when communicating with parents who have reading difficulties or whose first language is not English.

❖ **Removing a Suspension/ After the suspension ends:**

- A suspension will be removed if the Board of Management decides to do so for any reason or if the Secretary General of the Dept. of Education and Science directs that it should be removed.
- The period of suspension will, otherwise, end on the date given in the letter of notification to the parents about the suspension.
- When the period of suspension is completed the pupil will be given the opportunity and support for a fresh start.

❖ **Records and Reports:**

Formal written records will be kept of

- The investigation (including notes of all interviews held)
- The decision-making process
- The decision and rationale for the decision
- The duration of the suspension and any conditions attached to the suspension.
- The Principal will report all suspensions to the BOM.
- The Principal will report suspensions to 'TUSLA: Educational Welfare Services – Child and Family Agency' in accordance with guidelines.

❖ **Expulsion (permanent exclusion)**

A pupil is expelled from school when the Board of Management makes a decision to permanently exclude him or her from the school, having complied with section 24 of the Education Welfare Act 2000. Expulsion should be a proportionate response to the pupil's behaviour and should only be taken by the Board of Management in extreme cases of unacceptable behaviour. The following steps will be taken to address the misbehaviour and to avoid expulsion of a pupil:

- meeting with parents and the pupil to try to find ways to help the pupil to change his/ her behaviour
- making sure that the pupil understands the possible consequences of his/ her behaviour, if it should persist
- ensuring that all other possible options have been tried
- seeking the assistance of support agencies (e.g. National Psychological Service, Health Service Executive Community Services, The National Behavioural Support Service, Child and Adolescent Mental Health Services, National Council for Special Education).

The grounds for expulsion are similar to the grounds for suspension but will only be implemented when school authorities have tried a series of other interventions and believe that all possibilities for changing the pupil's behaviour have been exhausted.

❖ **Expulsion for a first offence:**

In exceptional circumstances the Board of Management can form the opinion that a student should be expelled for a first offence. Such behaviours may include:

- actual violence or physical assault against another pupil or member of staff
- supplying illegal drugs to other students in the school
- sexual assault

❖ **Procedures in respect of expulsion: The following steps will be strictly adhered to:**

- A detailed investigation will be carried out under the direction of the Principal.
- A recommendation will be made to the Board of Management by the Principal.
- The Board of management will consider the Principal's recommendation at a hearing.
- Board of Management will deliberate and take actions following the hearing.
- Consultations will be arranged by the Educational Welfare Officer.
- Confirmation will be made of the decision to expel.

These steps are explained in detail in the NEWB Book 'Developing a Code of Behaviour: Guidelines for Schools' as issued in May 2008 (pages 83- 86)

❖ **Appeals**

- Under Section 29 of the Education Act, 1998, parents are entitled to appeal to the Secretary General of the Department of Education and Science against some decisions of the Board of Management, including (1) permanent exclusion from a school and (2) suspension for a period which would bring the cumulative period of suspension to 20 school days or longer in any one school year. Accordingly, schools should advise parents of this right of appeal and associated timeframe if it has been decided to suspend or permanently exclude a pupil. Parents will be given a copy of Circular 22/02 and related forms. Appeals must be made within 42 calendar days from the date the decision of the school was notified to the parent or student. (Circular 22/02)
- A response will be prepared by the Board of Management if and when an appeal is being investigated by the Dept of Education and Science (Section 12, Circular 22/02 – Processing of an Appeal)

6. Keeping records

Records are written in a factual and impartial manner.

❖ Class level

- o Serious misbehaviour is reported to the principal as and when it occurs. The principal is also informed when repeated minor misbehaviour takes place and fails to be resolved using sanctions carried out by the class teacher.
- o The end of year report includes a reference to behaviour. There is a consistent understanding of what constitutes excellent – poor behaviour among the staff. Parents are kept up to date during the year regarding behaviour issues during parent /teacher meetings.

❖ Playground

- o Supervising teachers keep a record of serious/gross misbehaviour in the incident book. This information is passed onto other members of staff when it occurs.
- o Consistency in the application and interpretation of the rules is maintained through regular consultation amongst staff members.

❖ School records

- o Serious incidents will be recorded in an incident book. This book is stored in the filing cabinet in the office.
- o Formal records which are kept at school level include factual reports of particular incidents, communication between school and home, communication with outside agencies, Board of Management, documentation pertaining to appeals under Section 29 of the Education Act 1998.

7. Procedures for notification of pupil absences from school

- Section 18 of The Education Welfare Act, 2000 stipulates that parents must notify the school of a student's absence and the reason for this absence. Therefore, parents/guardians must send in a note informing teachers in writing of their child's absence from school and the reason for this absence. This Absence Form can now be submitted online via the school website. (Refer to Attendance Policy)
- The school uses the standard forms, on-line, to report on pupil absences to 'TUSLA: Educational Welfare Services – Child and Family Agency'. In accordance with the Education Welfare Act, the National Education Welfare Officer will be notified of absences of twenty days and above. The school will also notify parents when their child has been absent for twenty days.

8. Reference to other Policies

Other school policies that have a bearing on the code of behaviour:

- o SPHE plan
- o Anti-bullying Policy
- o Child Safeguarding and Risk Assessment Statement
- o Admissions Policy
- o Record keeping Policy
- o Health & Safety Policy
- o Equality Policy
- o Special Educational Needs Policy

- o Attendance Policy

These policies are available to parents on request.

Success Criteria:

The following are indicators of the success of the policy:

- Observation of positive behaviour in classrooms, playground and school environment
- Practices and procedures listed in this policy being consistently implemented by teachers
- Positive feedback from teachers, parents and pupils

Roles and Responsibilities:

- The Board of Management has been involved in formulating the policy and has the responsibility to act according to the guidelines regarding suspension and expulsion.
- Members of the teaching staff have responsibility for the implementation of this policy. The Board of management has the responsibility of ensuring that the guidelines pertaining to suspension and expulsion are strictly adhered to.
- The principal will coordinate and monitor the implementation of this policy.
- The principal and teachers, SNAs and any other teaching staff will act according to the policy.
- Pupils were involved in drawing up the original policy in 2017 by helping to form classroom and playground rules. Pupils were asked to review these rules in December 2021. They have a duty to adhere to these rules and co-operate with any sanctions that may need to be put in place.
- Parents were involved in the formulation of the original policy in 2017 and were invited to give feedback on the policy in November 2021 prior to review by the Board of Management. Parents have the responsibility to support the teaching staff and the Board of Management as they implement the policy.

Communication, Implementation, Ratification and Review:

This Code of Behaviour and its review has been considered by parents, teachers, pupils in the school and the Board of Management. The policy will be published on the school website. The code is mindful of the Curriculum, the school's Health & Safety Statement, Anti-Bullying Policy, Admissions Policy and Child Safeguarding and Risk Assessment Statement.

This Code of Behaviour came into effect on the 31st August 2017. The revised Code of Behaviour came into effect on the 13th December 2021. This policy will be reviewed in accordance with our school plan or as and when deemed necessary by the Board of Management.

The Board of Management officially ratified the policy on Tuesday, 4th April, 2017. It was reviewed and ratified on Friday 10th December 2021.

Signed by: _____ Dated: _____
Chairperson

Signed by: _____ Dated: _____
Principal

Appendix 1.

Classroom Rules:

- Pupils must cooperate fully with the teacher.
- Pupils are expected to behave respectfully towards teachers, parents, other pupils and visitors to the school.
- Pupils are expected to work to the best of their ability and to present written exercises neatly.
- Pupils must respect school property and the property of others.
- Pupils must not shout out answers in class and they must take turns as directed by the teacher.
- Bad language and rude gestures will not be tolerated.
- Pupils may only leave the classroom when they have the permission of the teacher.
- In the interest of safety, pupils are not allowed to run in the classroom.
- Pupils must use the bins provided for litter and for recycling. They must cooperate in keeping the classroom tidy.
- If the teacher has to leave the room, the pupils must remain seated and be of good behaviour.
- School bags should be stored neatly under pupils' tables.
- Pupils are not allowed to bring mobile phones, iPods, electronic games to school.
- Pupils are not allowed to bring in toys for their own recreational use.
- Pupils must keep the four legs of their chair on the floor and not lean back on their chairs.
- Pupils must adhere to Covid-19 prevention measures when applicable.
- Any form of bullying is not tolerated.

Playground Rules:

- Pupils may only go out to the playground when the teacher on duty is out there.
- Pupils must cooperate fully with the teacher on duty.
- Pupils must respect school property.
- Pupils must not behave in a manner which may harm themselves or others.
- Bad language or rude gestures will not be tolerated.
- Any form of bullying will not be tolerated.
- Spitting is forbidden.
- In the interest of safety, the climbing of walls and gates is forbidden.
- Pupils must not go down the side or the back of the school unless they have permission.
- Pupils may only enter the school building during break time with permission from the teacher on duty.
- Pupils from the senior classroom are responsible for gathering litter from the yard.
- All pupils must respect the fact that the playground is an area for all age groups at break time and they should avoid any play or behaviour that endangers themselves or others.
- Pupils are not allowed outside the school gates during school hours without permission.
- Pupils must not gather around the step at the door.
- Pupils should not harm or kill any little creatures that live in the school yard and should not interfere with the plants.

